

# The Mechanics of Public Sector Procurement

How UK Buyers Choose, Evaluate, and Assure Cloud Infrastructure

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## Introduction

Procurement is not a side note in UK public sector cloud adoption. It is the process by which choices are justified, scrutinised, and defended. For Oracle Cloud Infrastructure (OCI) to be adopted, our customers must be able to pass their own boards, satisfy assurance bodies, and comply with Cabinet Office controls. In 2025 those controls are more structured than ever. The Procurement Act 2023 is in force, G-Cloud 14 governs much of the catalogue spend, and sector frameworks in health, policing, and defence all overlay central rules with their own assurance patterns.

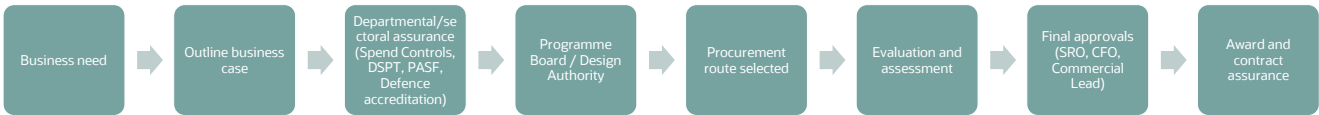
This paper explains how those mechanics work. It sets out who signs off, which routes to market are available, what criteria tip the balance, and which assurance gates must be passed. The aim is practical: to equip Oracle architects with a grounded map of decision-making so that OCI bids withstand scrutiny and move forward without delay.

## How UK Public Bodies Decide

Unlike many private-sector organisations, where even major infrastructure contracts may be signed off by one or two senior executives, UK public sector procurement is deliberately more protracted. It moves through a chain of decision gates designed to test need, value, compliance, and risk before any award is signed. The same broad pattern applies across central departments, the NHS, police forces, and defence, though each sector layers in its own oversight.

- **Central Government and Arm's-Length Bodies:** Departments must clear the Cabinet Office Digital and Technology Spend Controls for significant cloud projects. These controls, updated in July 2025, classify spend by risk and importance and require outline cases to show alignment with the Technology Code of Practice and Government Functional Standard GovS 005. Internal Programme Boards and Design or Architecture Authorities then review the business case and technical approach. Final approvals usually rest with the Senior Responsible Owner (SRO), advised by the CIO/CDO, SIRO, CISO, Finance Director, and Commercial Lead.
- **NHS Bodies:** For NHS England, Integrated Care Boards, and NHS Trusts, assurance is shaped by information governance requirements. Every cloud project must demonstrate alignment with the Data Security and Protection Toolkit (DSPT) and complete a Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) where patient data is involved. Clinical safety officers may also be required to sign off when systems affect care pathways. Procurement typically moves through a Trust Board or ICB governance committee, with sign-off from the SIRO and Caldicott Guardian.
- **Policing:** Police forces buy independently but under the influence of national governance set by the Police Digital Service (PDS) and the National Policing Digital Strategy 2025–2030. This strategy defines national boards that review business cases and live services, including the Portfolio Assurance Group and the National Live Service Board. Local approvals normally involve the Chief Information Officer, Force Information Assurance Lead, and Commercial Lead, with reference to Police Assured Secure Facilities (PASF) where hosting or interconnection is relevant.
- **Defence:** The Ministry of Defence operates under the Procurement Act 2023 but applies additional accreditation and assurance through Defence Digital. Hyperscale adoption is guided by the Cloud Strategic Roadmap for Defence and the Defence Digital Foundry. Decision-making flows through programme boards, Defence Commercial, and security accreditors, with final approvals by the SRO and senior finance officers. Defence primes may act as intermediaries, carrying the responsibility to evidence alignment with NCSC cloud principles and classification-appropriate controls.

Decision Gates in UK Public Sector Cloud Procurement



Default Routes to Market

Public sector buyers in the UK do not choose cloud providers directly. They must use approved commercial routes that frame how requirements are expressed, how competition is conducted, and how awards are documented. These routes differ by sector but all sit under the Procurement Act 2023, which came fully into force in October 2024.

1. **G-Cloud 14:** The most widely used catalogue for cloud hosting, software, and support. G-Cloud 14 went live in November 2024 for an 18-month period, allowing call-offs of up to three years plus one year extension. Buyers can either place a direct award from catalogue listings or run a further competition. Call-offs are constrained by the published service definitions, but evaluation weightings are set by the buyer.
2. **Cloud Compute 2 (RM6292):** A Crown Commercial Service framework focused on larger infrastructure and platform services. Departments use it when requirements exceed the scope of catalogue call-offs, or when they want a multi-year, outcome-based contract. Call-offs usually require a mini-competition with clear evaluation criteria.
3. **Procurement Act 2023 Procedures:** Where frameworks do not apply, buyers use Find a Tender under the Act. The Competitive Flexible Procedure is now common for complex data-centre exits or multi-tower transitions. The Open Procedure is used for well-specified requirements. Direct awards are possible only in narrow conditions, and must be accompanied by transparency notices.
4. **NHS Commercial Routes:** NHS bodies often rely on CCS frameworks, but NHS England also issues national prospectuses and operating models that pre-signal which frameworks should be used. Every procurement must demonstrate DSP Toolkit compliance before award.
5. **Police Digital Service (PDS):** Police forces draw on CCS frameworks but are increasingly steered by national strategy. PDS provides frameworks and national agreements that cover infrastructure, cloud services, and integration. National boards sign off shared services, ensuring alignment with standards such as PASF.
6. **Defence:** The Ministry of Defence uses CCS frameworks for commodity services but often routes hyperscale hosting through defence primes or bespoke competitions under the Act. Accreditation packs are mandatory, and Defence Digital plays a central assurance role. The Defence Digital Foundry provides reference environments for AI and data workloads at higher classifications.

Routes to Market by Sector

| Route                    | Sector fit                             | When to use                                    | Evaluation constraints                                  | Example award                                    |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| G-Cloud 14 (RM1557.14)   | Central, NHS, Police, Defence-adjacent | Defined cloud services; catalogue listings     | Must use published definitions; call-offs max 3+1 years | 2025: Heritage Gateway API hosting, direct award |
| Cloud Compute 2 (RM6292) | Central departments, large NHS         | Larger IaaS/PaaS buys, outcome-based contracts | Mini-competition; outcome-focused criteria              | Ongoing CCS call-offs for compute                |

|                                    |                                  |                                                    |                                                     |                                            |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Competitive Flexible Procedure     | All sectors                      | Complex transitions or data-centre exits           | Buyer designs stages; requires transparency notices | HMRC hyperscaler procurement               |
| Open Procedure                     | All sectors                      | Straightforward, well-defined requirements         | Single-stage; full tender on Find a Tender          | Commodity cloud tooling procurements       |
| NHS national prospectuses / models | NHS England, Trusts, ICBs        | Clinical or data-driven programmes                 | Must show DSPT compliance and IG artefacts          | Federated Data Platform procurement model  |
| PDS frameworks and agreements      | Police forces, national policing | Multi-force or national services                   | Oversight from national boards; PASF where relevant | PDS Xchange platform supporting biometrics |
| Defence via CCS or primes          | MoD and defence primes           | OFFICIAL to SECRET workloads with defence overlays | Defence accreditation packs; Act compliance         | Defence Digital Foundry procurements       |

## Evaluation Criteria That Decide Outcomes

Procurements in the UK public sector are assessed against a blend of quality, price, and social value. The balance varies, but several patterns recur across sectors. Understanding these patterns allows Oracle architects to prepare evidence in ways that align with buyer expectations.

1. **Quality vs Price Splits:** Central government procurements must apply the Social Value Model, with at least ten percent of the total score allocated to social value. A typical split is 60 percent quality, 30 percent price, 10 percent social value. In practice, buyers adjust weightings depending on the complexity of the service. NHS bodies sometimes reduce the number of social value themes to keep the assessment proportionate but still apply the ten percent minimum.
2. **Technical Merit and Assurance:** Quality is most often measured through technical merit, compliance with the Technology Code of Practice, and alignment to NCSC cloud security principles. Buyers expect suppliers to map their services against these principles and to explain the shared responsibility model in practical terms.
3. **Predictability of Cost and Delivery:** Evaluators look closely at price predictability. This is typically assessed through evidence of cost controls such as tagging, budgeting, showback/chargeback, and support for consumption monitoring. Buyers are less interested in price–performance claims than in confidence that budgets will not be destabilised.
4. **Portability and Exit:** Since the Procurement Act 2023 and the influence of the EU Data Act (which applies to EU customers from September 2025), buyers are increasingly seeking evidence of exit planning and portability. Even where the UK regulation does not directly apply, contracting authorities expect suppliers to support switching and to document the tools and processes available.
5. **Resilience and Support:** Service resilience, tested through disaster recovery objectives and regional redundancy, is a scored element in many competitions. Equally important is the supplier’s support model, including incident response, escalation, and ongoing assurance reporting.

## Evaluation Criteria and Evidence Patterns

| Criterion              | How evidenced                                              | Typical weighting examples                                             | Notes for OCI architects                               |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Technical merit        | Mapping to TCoP, NCSC principles, architecture diagrams    | Often the majority of the quality score                                | Prepare NCSC principle mappings early                  |
| Compliance & assurance | DSPT (NHS), PASF (Police), Defence accreditation packs     | Usually pass/fail with scored risk                                     | Align responses to sector-specific artefacts           |
| Social value           | Delivery against national model themes                     | Min. 10% in central gov; NHS guidance to limit to proportionate themes | Provide measurable, relevant commitments               |
| Price predictability   | Cost control tooling, FinOps practices, KPI examples       | Part of price or quality depending on route                            | Show evidence of tagging, budgeting, anomaly detection |
| Portability & exit     | Exit plans, tooling for migration, data export commitments | Quality sub-criterion; sometimes explicit requirement                  | Document switching support without making TCO claims   |
| Resilience             | Multi-region design, DR testing, RTO/RPO commitments       | Quality sub-criterion                                                  | Evidence patterns and test artefacts are valuable      |
| Support model          | SLAs, incident management, escalation pathways             | Quality sub-criterion                                                  | Provide clarity on Oracle support tiers and escalation |

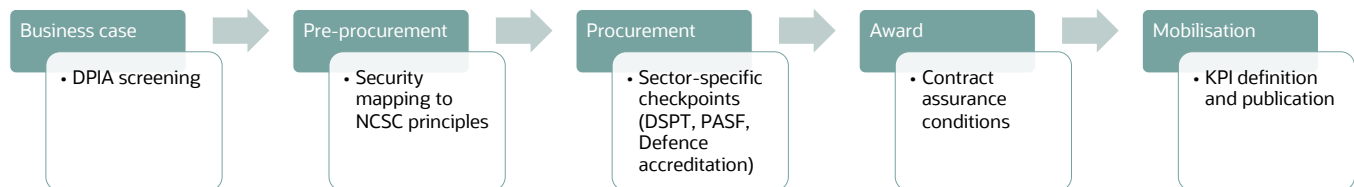
## Assurance and Compliance Checkpoints

Procurement decisions in the UK public sector are not finalised when an award notice is issued. Every major contract must pass a set of assurance and compliance checks before services can go live. These checkpoints differ by sector but follow a common sequence: data protection, security, and sector-specific assurance.

- **Data Protection and Privacy:** Most cloud procurements require a Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA). Templates are published by the Information Commissioner's Office and are adapted by many NHS bodies and local authorities. Completion of a DPIA is usually a condition of contract signature. Buyers expect suppliers to support the process by providing data flow diagrams, storage locations, and retention practices (ICO, 2025).
- **Security:** The NCSC Cloud Security Principles remain the baseline assurance framework. Security teams assess how services meet principles such as data in transit protection, identity and access control, audit logging, and incident response. Suppliers are expected to present a clear shared responsibility model and provide evidence of controls.
- **NHS:** For NHS England and Trusts, compliance with the Data Security and Protection Toolkit (DSPT) is mandatory. Suppliers must show their services will allow consuming organisations to maintain DSPT compliance. Where systems impact clinical decisions, a clinical safety officer must sign off artefacts such as hazard logs and safety cases.
- **Policing:** Police forces reference Police Assured Secure Facilities (PASF) when cloud services interconnect with facilities or require specific secure handling. PASF accreditation is therefore a recurring requirement even in cloud-adjacent procurements. Local Information Assurance leads review compliance and escalate to national boards where relevant.

- **Defence:** Defence Digital applies classification-specific accreditation. Cloud services at OFFICIAL or above must map to the NCSC principles and pass Defence accreditation regimes. Defence primes often carry responsibility for assembling assurance packs, which include detailed security cases, performance KPIs, and monitoring arrangements.
- **Portability and Switching:** Since the Procurement Act 2023, authorities must include provisions for termination, exit, and data portability. The EU Data Act, which takes effect for EU customers from September 2025, reinforces this trend by mandating switching capabilities. UK buyers increasingly ask for exit strategies to be evidenced up front, even where the regulation is not directly binding.

### Assurance Checkpoints Overlay



### Checklist for Assurance Readiness

|                                     |                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Prepare DPIA support pack: data flows, storage, retention, processing locations.             |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Map services against the 14 NCSC Cloud Security Principles.                                  |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Document shared responsibility model, logging, and incident response.                        |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | For NHS bids: supply DSPT evidence, IG alignment, and clinical safety artefacts if required. |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | For police bids: confirm PASF requirements and provide accreditation evidence.               |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | For defence bids: assemble security case aligned to Defence Digital accreditation.           |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Include exit and portability commitments in the bid pack.                                    |

## Recent Awards, Patterns, and Lessons

Public buyers leave a trail. Each award notice sets out the route chosen, the criteria applied, and the justification given. Read in isolation, they are simply transactions. Read together, they chart how cloud is actually being bought in 2024–2025.

The picture that emerges is not surprising, but it is clarifying. **G-Cloud 14 continues to dominate** as the vehicle for most hosting and hosting-adjacent awards. Departments, NHS bodies, police forces and even the MoD are all using it, whether through direct awards or mini-competitions. The notices show the familiar 3+1 structure, with contracts framed to align to catalogue constraints. In some cases, buyers go further and state explicitly that *price alone* was the

deciding factor. At first glance this might look like commoditisation, but it is more a reflection of how defined some of these services have become: where scope is narrow, evaluation follows suit.

At the other end of the spectrum, **complex transitions are being channelled through the new Competitive Flexible Procedure** under the Procurement Act 2023. HMRC's data-centre exit is the most visible example. It has set out a staged process that runs until 2028, with the intent to move wholesale to a single hyperscaler while allowing subcontracting for specific elements. What matters here is not the technology per se, but the governance: risk logs, migration controls, accreditation milestones, and performance measures that can be published in assessment summaries. This shows how the Act is shaping behaviour.

Taken together, these examples remind us that procurement is both structured and varied. It is structured in that the same frameworks and procedures are being applied across sectors; varied in how buyers weight their criteria and frame their risks. For Oracle architects, the lesson is not to memorise every notice but to absorb the rhythm: catalogue awards for the defined and familiar, flexible procedures for the complex and strategic, and desktop assessments as the connective tissue between the two. This rhythm is predictable enough to prepare for, yet nuanced enough to demand sector-aware evidence every time.

## Implications for OCI Architects

Procurement mechanics decide whether an OCI proposal advances, stalls, or is ruled ineligible. For architects, the implication is clear: every design must be backed by an evidence pack that aligns to decision gates, evaluation criteria, and assurance requirements.

Three practices matter most. First, **build the evidence early**. Bids rarely succeed on technical diagrams alone. They require a supporting set of artefacts; DPIAs, NCSC-aligned security mappings, portability statements, and cost-predictability notes. These are faster to tailor when a baseline set already exists.

Second, **select the route to market with the customer**. A G-Cloud call-off constrains evaluation to what is written in the service description, while a staged procedure under the Procurement Act 2023 allows dialogue and iteration. NHS and policing frameworks add their own overlays, such as DSPT or PASF. Knowing which path the buyer is taking allows us to frame OCI in the right terms from the outset.

Third, **anticipate the boards**. Spend controls, programme boards, and assurance committees are not afterthoughts. They are structured checkpoints that test risk mitigation, reversibility, resilience, and governance. Architects who present designs in this language equip sponsors to defend the choice of OCI under scrutiny.

## Conclusion

Procurement is where strategy meets reality. It is the process through which public sector bodies turn ambition into contracts, and where OCI must demonstrate not only technical capability but also compliance, portability, and accountability. In 2025, that process is shaped by the Procurement Act, Cabinet Office controls, and sector frameworks that demand more evidence, more assurance, and more transparency than before.

This paper has traced how decisions are made, which routes to market are available, what criteria tip the balance, and where assurance is tested. The intent is not to restate what many of you already know in depth, but to set out the mechanics in a way that shows their structure and their parallels across sectors.

The knowledge should be treated as a living artefact. Frameworks evolve, weighting shifts, and assurance expectations rise. Keeping your awareness current is as important as refining the designs themselves.

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